

team. Australia, for instance. I faced a similar situation when Duncan Fletcher and I took over in 1999. We were at rock bottom, we had been knocked out of our own World Cup, we lost to New Zealand and were the world's second-worst side, and we didn't have the talent the Indian side had. Some of the selectors were saying, get rid of the old guard, get new players in, but I wanted a few senior players to set the tone in the dressing room. I wanted Alec Stewart, Mike Atherton, Darren Gough and a few others in my side.

It's a gradual process and you need good, solid, senior players to guide the youngsters. You probably don't need that in a T20 tournament spanning two weeks, but say it's a three-month

Dravid and Laxman and the left armers bowl, they will continue to be a good Test match side.

But in ODIs, I think, maybe it's time for a bit of a cull. I think India should do it one at a time. Like Laxman has now gone from the ODI side, it is probably time for one more to go. The problem with Indian cricket is politics. This is what coaches find, this is what Chappell found, this is what the selectors find. The moment you name one person, half the country is split. You only have to go back to the Ganguly episode. You try and do things for the forward movement of the team and all that it does is create a political situa-

VICTORY MARCH: T20 will throw up new challengers for the ODI order



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tour of Australia, where the lads haven't played, or the Pakistan series. When things start going the wrong way, you need the senior pros to guide the younger players.

In Test match cricket, I would retain the gems, the fab four of Dravid, Tendulkar, Ganguly and Laxman. They are world-class Test players. We saw in the England series that you can still amble on at your pace—an Indian pace, if you want to call it that—in the field and get away with it. They dropped some catches, but they got away with that as well. They weren't very mobile on the field, but if Sachin gets his runs, along with Ganguly,

tion that divides the country.

The one person I certainly wouldn't give up on yet is Tendulkar. I interviewed him for my newspaper and he still came across as someone desperately in love with the game. He wasn't just doing it for the money or the sponsors or because he's got nothing else to do. Talking to him was like talking to Graham Gooch or Stewart, who played cricket because they absolutely loved the game. I asked Sachin a question about what he was going to do after cricket. He sort of looked at me blankly because this is what life has been for him since he was a 10-year-old.

From what I saw of him in England,

I wouldn't certainly call time on Tendulkar. The only thing with him, and it was noticeable in England, is that his body is beginning to fall apart on him a little bit because of one-day cricket. He admitted that the first thing that would give way wouldn't be his mind, which looked very sharp and strong, it would be his body.

Dravid is one person that India should hold on to for as long as possible in some way. I'm not sure about ODI, so I won't make any categorical statements about that. But whoever takes over, be it Dhoni or anyone else, will need Dravid around as a shoulder to lean on and also to see how Dravid goes about his business. He's a little bit like Stewart, very meticulous, very organised and a very good example.

In these two weeks, the World T20 has found its place in cricket. I'm not of the argument that T20 will eventually take over everything, because there's a place in sport for variety. In golf, there's your weekly tour events, the President's Cup and the Ryder Cup. It doesn't mean the Ryder Cup is the be-all-and-end-all of everything. You have to go back to your Masters, go back to the weekly tour. It's the same with Twenty20. It will stand like it is, a one-off tournament, played every two years, which is great. Twenty20 will be played domestically or at the start of a series to spice things up, or maybe at the end. I don't think it will kill 50-over cricket or Test cricket.

There will be T20 specialists who will suddenly be knocking on the 50-over door, like Sharma has. T20 will put pressure on the 50-over plodders if they realise there is a younger generation that can break through. What T20 will also do is what 50-over cricket has done to Test match cricket. People like Adam Gilchrist and a few others realised they could play the same way in 50-over cricket and Test cricket. T20 will actually show, to Yuvraj and a few others, that they can, if they want to, clear the boundary at any time. It is up to them to choose the time to hit the big sixes. More than any other consequence, I somehow think India might enjoy that the most.

Nasser Hussain is a former England cricket captain.